

MSRP Proposal Meeting

Black Women's Cambridge

A Case Study on Digital Counter-mapping and Black Feminist Geographies

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“Black women’s geographies open up a meaningful way to approach both the power and possibilities of geographic inquiry”

Katherine McKittrick, *Demonic Grounds* (2006)

Using social media and GIS as counter-mapping tools

How can digital technologies
reveal and visualize Black
women's geographies?

Background

Black women's geographies describe how Black women's uniquely intersectional experience of racial-sexual hierarchies and oppression shape our creation and definition of geographic landscapes.

Our perspectives and “social practices create landscapes and contribute to how we organize, build, and imagine our surroundings” (McKittrick, 2006).

Incorporating these geographies into social science research minimizes the erasure of Black women and centers their experiences and geographic epistemologies.

These critical ways of knowing acknowledge “how those structures ignore the ways exclusionary epistemologies uphold racist, sexist, classist, and ableist oppressions” (Garrison-Harrison, 2025).

Existing visualization work does not incorporate this intersectional perspective.

Feminist GIS “aims at illuminating those aspects of everyday life that can be meaningfully depicted using GIS methods” (Kwan 2002), and digital mapping has been discussed as a feminist research method that “can provide a generative and participant-centred tool for conducting research in line with feminist principles.”

A design research case study of Black feminist counter-mapping using geolocated social media posts, census data, and ArcGIS to locate and map Black women's geographies of Cambridge.

Data Collection: Locating Black women's geographies

Though sources emphasize the importance of participatory design in future works with feminist geographies and counter mapping, I feel that a small-scale qualitative analysis could be a much more reasonable task for 6 weeks as an individual researcher.

Social Media

What places to Black women frequent, create, and invite others into? What places do they avoid, lament, or warn against? What do they do in those spaces?

Census Data

Where do these women live? What are their ages, educational levels, income, etc.? How are they distributed through Cambridge?

Data Analysis: Black feminist critical epistemological approach

Parsing social media posts for

- Sentiments about various Cambridge locations
- Common posting locations
- Commonly mentioned gathering spots and community hubs
- Interpersonal experiences in Cambridge

Parsing metadata for

- Aggregate activity space
- Timelines of activity

Acknowledging my Positionality

I will focus on the expressed sentiments from the social media posts because I am not from Cambridge

Developing Competency

I will familiarize myself with qualitative data analysis on QualCoder, and seek assistance/feedback to progress faster.

Moral and Ethical Connection

I will acknowledge my lived experience as a Black woman and my position as an outsider to the city of Cambridge

Design: Feminist Visualization with GIS

Key Questions to guide map design

- What is the purpose of the map, is there a story to be told?
- Who are the target users and/or other potential users?
- What is the map use environment?
- Which type of medium will be used to make the map—static or interactive, paper or digital?

Practicing and Documenting Reflexivity

With each design decision, I will return to these guiding questions.

What about the purpose, target user, use case, or medium led me to this decision?

Additionally, I will apply my existing competencies in web development and develop new competencies in ArcGIS.

Feminist Data Visualization

- **Make labor visible:** record and visualize metadata that reflects both my labor and that of the Black women whose posts I reference
- **Legitimize Embodiment and Affect:** Work to convey how the bodily experiences of spaces are described and emphasize this as knowledge
- **Embrace Pluralism:** Include competing perspectives where possible, acknowledge less-frequently noted information

(D'Ignazio & Klein, 2016; Kelley 2023; Kwan 2002; Ricker et al., 2020)

Proposed Work Plan

Week 3: June 21-27

Data Collection

Week 4: June 28 - July 4

Data Analysis

Find inspirations and storyboard

**Need Confirmed Research
Supervisor by July 5**

Week 5: July 5-11

Feedback on storyboard

Work on Map Design, seek
feedback

Week 6: July 12-18

Refining and Finalizing Map
Design

**Draft of Scientific Abstract due
July 12**

Week 7: July 19 - 25

Drafting Poster

**Final Abstract, Poster Draft due
July 26**

Week 8: July 26 - August 1

Finish Poster

**Final Research Poster due
August 2**

References

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